

our lot, modern culture is determinedly pushing us not to settle for less than we are worth. The rise of ‘girlboss culture’ throughout the 2010s encouraged women to challenge the system, and to be loud about it, in the name of feminism, and though there has been something of a reckoning for this movement (which mainly centred around wealthy white women and still seemed to measure a person’s value by the same patriarchal, capitalist yardstick as before), there are still some relics of it in the way that we view success in the 2020s. As we watched female-only club The Wing and other artefacts of selective feminism dissolve into a pile of scalloped pink tiles and mustard velvet following allegations of racism, ablism and bullying,² we were forced to confront our own ideas about true success vs the perception of success. There has to be a balance that we can strike between languishing in a state of despondency and discontent and pushing ourselves so hard towards an arbitrary, moving idea of success that we burn out before we even get to enjoy the fruits of our labour. It’s the same with money, and, in fact, given how closely work and money are related, our career and financial goals should usually align if we’re hoping to encourage financial wellbeing.

This is where the hedonic treadmill theory is useful to us in explaining why nothing we ever do – no promotion, no amount of money, no level of material comfort – ever feels enough. Why our achievements, whether in our financial, personal or work lives, quickly fade into insignificance once we actually achieve them. The hedonic treadmill, or hedonic